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THE SECOND INNINGS

ON 16 December 2014, six Pakistani Taliban gunmen entered the Army Public School in Peshawar and conducted what would become one of the deadliest massacres of all time. One hundred and forty-nine people were killed, of which 132 were schoolchildren aged between eight and 18. Eventually, the Pakistani military forces would launch an operation and kill the gunmen, but by then Pakistan would be a different country.

I wasn't in Pakistan at the time but what I started seeing on WhatsApp about the attacks was disturbing. I didn't want to believe it. None of it. It felt like these were photos and clips from Syria or Afghanistan, not Pakistan. I didn't want to believe it and indeed, I could not believe it.

But there's always a silver lining. Even in the death of over 100 kids. The incident woke up our nation. The National Action Plan was drafted. The opposition and the government got their house in order. The army got clear directives about the end goal: wipe out terrorism. It woke us up, even those among us who were on the fence.

I'm disappointed with our political leadership, though. Politics is a business in Pakistan. The leadership is not the kind of national leadership meant to inspire. It's all about partisan, vested, limited or personal interests. There is no long-term plan for the country. There is no national vision to fight crime. There is no common policy to tackle joblessness. There is not a single page, nor a proposal on how we can improve our national pastime and love: cricket.

Our politicians, insecure that they are, try to grab what they can in the few years they get in office. Achieving public office is not to retain the public's trust but the public's wealth. Most of them are there to plunder wealth.

As for the army, I'm afraid they don't have any idea about politics. They know a lot about politicians but they don't know politics. This is a fact. Their coming to power is always to fill a vacuum. It's a desperate move. But soon, even they start playing political games and thus become dependent on corrupt politicians. That's when things start going downhill for the country.

General Pervez Musharraf, former president of Pakistan, is the perfect example of this. He got